

The Separatist Conflict in Donbas: A Violent Break-Up of Ukraine?

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Abstract

Ukraine has experienced significant regional divisions concerning such issues as support for leading presidential candidates and political parties, foreign orientation, and attitudes towards major historical events since it became independent in 1991. Separatism in various forms manifested itself in Crimea in the first half of the 1990s and in Donbas and neighboring regions during the “Orange Revolution” in 2004. However, Ukraine was able until 2014 to avoid a violent break-up, in contrast to such post-communist countries as Azerbaijan, Georgia, Moldova, and former Yugoslavia. In 2014, Crimea seceded with help of Russian military intervention, and it was annexed by Russia. Pro-Russian separatists with direct involvement of large groups of armed Russians with indirect Russian government support seized power in most of Donbas and engaged in a violent conflict with pro-government forces in the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions (Donbas). The research question is as to why Ukraine has suffered a violent separatist conflict in Donbas. This study analyses the role of different actors and factors in the violent conflict in Donbas. This paper uses a brief survey, which was commissioned by the author and conducted by the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology (KIIS) in the end of April and the beginning of May 2014, to analyze support for separatism in Donbas, compared to other regions of Ukraine, and major factors which affect such support. It compares the role of the Yanukovich and post-Yanukovich governments in Ukraine, the Russian and Western governments, political leaders of these countries, and Russian and Ukrainian paramilitary formations. This paper also compares the violent separatist conflict in the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions to other similar violent conflicts and to secessions of Transdnistria in Moldova, Abkhazia and South Ossetia in Georgia, Nagorno-Karabakh in Azerbaijan, Krajina in Croatia, Republika Srpska in Bosnia, and Kosovo in Serbia.

The Question of Separatism in Donbas

Ukraine since its independence from the Soviet Union in 1991 has experienced significant regional divisions concerning such major domestic politics and foreign orientation issues, as electoral support for major presidential candidates and political parties, status of the Russian language, Ukraine's membership in the European Union and NATO, and its relations with Russia. There have been similar divides concerning major historical conflicts involving the Organization of Ukrainian Nationalists and the Ukrainian Insurgent Army. Many previous academic studies have shown existence of strong regional divisions concerning such political issues and historical conflicts in Ukraine. However, most of these studies examined such divisions before the "Orange Revolution" and the "Euromaidan," and relatively few of them analyzed separatism in Ukraine.¹

Major developments after the "Euromaidan" brought new attention to the issue of regional divisions, and specifically separatism in Ukraine. The Crimean autonomy along with Sevastopol city seceded from Ukraine in March 2014 with help of Russian military intervention. These two regions in Southern Ukraine were then annexed by Russia. Pro-Russian separatists with direct involvement of large groups of armed Russians seized power in most of Donbas (Donetsk and Luhansk Regions) in Eastern Ukraine and proclaimed the Donetsk People's Republic (DNR) and the Luhansk People's Republic (LNR). A large-scale violent conflict began in Donbas between separatists and the central government forces, aided by special police battalions, and formed with significant involvement of the far right organizations and the Maidan Self-Defense and the Right Sector. The conflict also became a major international conflict and the biggest conflict between the Russia and the West after the end of the Cold War. The Russian government supported separatists in Donbas indirectly and then directly by means of a military

intervention. The Western government backed the new Ukrainian government that came to power following the “Euromaidan” and its attempt to suppress separatists by force, but they ruled out their direct military intervention in this conflict in Ukraine.

The research question is as to why Ukraine has suffered a violent separatist conflict in Donbas. This study analyses the role of different actors and factors in the violent conflict in Donbas. It compares the role of the Yanukovych and post-Yanukovych governments in Ukraine, the Russian and Western governments, political leaders of these countries, and Russian and Ukrainian paramilitary formations.

This paper also uses a brief survey, which was commissioned by the author and conducted by the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology in the end of April and the beginning of May 2014, to analyze support for separatism in Donbas, compared to other regions of Ukraine, and major factors which affect pro-separatist attitudes. The analysis uses daily review of various Ukrainian and Western media reports, separatist news websites, live broadcasts, videos, and other sources concerning the conflict. It also compares the violent separatist conflict in the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions to other violent regional conflicts and secessions, such as Transdnistria in Moldova, Abkhazia and South Ossetia in Georgia, Nagorno-Karabakh in Azerbaijan, Krajina in Croatia, Republika Srpska in Bosnia, and Kosovo in Serbia.

Separatism in its various forms in independent Ukraine manifested itself in Crimea, in Donbas, and to a lesser extent in some neighboring regions. Pro-Russian separatist leaders and parties were in power in Crimea in first half of the 1990s. There was a real possibility of secession of Crimea at that time. Separatism also emerged in Donbas during the same time period, but it had weaker support there, compared to Crimea. In the end of 2004, the Party of Regions led by Viktor Yanukovych attempted to proclaim an autonomous republic in the East

and the South during the “Orange Revolution” when a fraudulent victory of Yanukovych in the presidential elections was overturned as a result of mass protests. Ukraine then also came close to a violent conflict and a possible break-up.²

However, in spite of such manifestations of separatism and significant and persistent regional divisions, only a few scholars considered a break-up and a violent regional conflict in Ukraine as significant possibilities.³ For instance, a study of regional cleavages and conflicts in Ukraine and Moldova argued that Ukraine came close to a violent break-up and civil war during the “Orange Revolution,” which received strongest support in Western Ukraine and some regions in the Center, such as Kyiv City, and that a possibility of such a break-up and an internal violent conflict, which took place in neighboring Moldova, remained in Ukraine.⁴ Many other studies either ignored such issues as insignificant or argued that even though Ukraine was divided along regional lines, it was unlikely to experience secession of its regions or a violent regional conflict. For example, some studies concluded that a potential conflict in Crimea was successfully prevented by the central government of Ukraine, that pro-Russian secessionist movement there failed, and that this autonomous region became integrated into the Ukrainian polity.⁵

Similarly, the attempt to proclaim an autonomous republic in the East and the South during the “Orange Revolution” was treated as an artificial separatism. With a few exceptions, separatism in Donbas and neighboring regions of Ukraine received no scholarly treatment.⁶ In spite of such strong regional divisions and previous manifestations of separatism, Ukraine was able until 2014 to avoid a violent break-up, in contrast to other post-communist countries, such as Azerbaijan, Georgia, Moldova, and former Yugoslavia.

The “Euromaidan” in the end of 2013 and the beginning of 2014 demonstrated the same patterns of regional divisions as the “Orange Revolution” in terms of their bases of popular support and mass actions of protests. But in contrast to the “Orange Revolution,” the “Euromaidan” involved not only mass actions of political protests against the government but also violent attacks of the seats of power, such as the presidential administration and the parliament, and seizures of regional administrations and police and security services offices. However, only a few scholars raised a possibility that the “Euromaidan” could lead to a break-up of Ukraine and a violent conflict, such as civil war.⁷

The Ukrainian government and the media and, to a large extent, their Western counterparts attributed the rise of separatism in Donbas mostly to direct military intervention by Russia. They presented the separatist rebellion in Donbas as started and led from its beginning in Spring of 2014 by armed Russian military units and Russian military intelligence agents, who lacked popular backing in this region. For example, the governments of Ukraine, the US, and Canada, top NATO officials, and mainstream Western mass media, such as BBC, CNN, and the New York Times, claimed that Russian military and intelligence units or “green men,” called after the color of uniforms of Russian soldiers without insignia during their military intervention in Crimea, were leading the separatist fight in Donbas from its start.⁸

The Ukrainian and Western governments and the media characterized separatism in Donbas as having a minor support and presented the results of a referendum held by separatists after they seized power there as not reflecting public preferences. They maintained that the Ukrainian government came to power a result of peaceful mass protests after then President Yanukovich and many members of his government fled Ukraine to avoid responsibility for ordering the “snipers” massacre of protesters on February 20, 2014, and that the Ukrainian

government had a legal power to suppress separatism by force. The post-Yanukovych government of Ukraine characterized separatists as “terrorists” and its military operation in Donbas as “the anti-terrorist operation” (ATO). It denied responsibility for civilian casualties during a war there by claiming that separatists themselves were killing residents of cities and villages in which they were based. The US and many other Western governments generally eschew the issue of civilian casualties, claimed lack of evidence to determine responsibility for the deadly attacks, or argued that the Ukrainian government forces showed restraint in using force. The same concerns the Odesa massacre of some 40 separatists and employees in a trade union building on May 2, 2014.

In contrast, the Russian government and media presented separatism in all Eastern and Southern Ukraine as having widespread popular support. Russian President Vladimir Putin referred to this part of Ukraine as “Novorossiya” (New Russia), a name of a historical region when it belonged to the Russian Empire. The Russian government since the start of the conflict in Donbas consistently denied its military intervention in Eastern Ukraine. A Russian government investigative agency used the term “genocide” when it launched its investigation into the “genocide of the Russian-speaking population” in Donbas.⁹

Many separatist and Russian politicians and the pro-separatist and Russian media claimed that a “fascist junta” seized power in Ukraine as a result of a coup d’état and that separatists, including Russian volunteers, defended people of Donbas from Ukrainian “fascists.” Some separatist leaders and commanders stated that they intended to expand their control to other regions of “Novorossiya” and even overthrow the central government in Kyiv City.

Analysis

The mass anti-government protests started in Ukraine in the end of November 2013 after a Yanukovych refusal to sign an association and free trade agreement with the European Union (EU). The conflict escalated and turned violent on November 30 after special police units (Berkut) violently dispersed a relatively small group of protesters on the Maidan. The mass protests against the police violence followed on December 1 in Kyiv City. In addition to peaceful rallies, they included seizures of the Kyiv City Hall and the Trade Union Building by a radical wing of the opposition and a violent attack led by radical nationalist and neo-Nazi organizations and football ultras, which formed the “Right Sector” alliance, on the presidential administration. Yanukovych attempted again to disperse protesters on the Maidan by force and adopted laws restricting freedoms of assembly and protest. In the end of January, the far right elements of the opposition, led by the Right Sector and football ultras, led an attack on the parliament. The attack escalated the conflict, and it resulted in a violent confrontation and a stand-off with the special police and interior troops units. Still unresolved killings of three protesters and a few others highly publicized but unresolved cases of violence, which the opposition attributed to the Yanukovych forces, further escalated the violent conflict.

Opposition leaders initially condemned the December 1 and the January attacks as “provocations.” Yanukovych also resorted to negotiations with the leaders of the pro-Western opposition under pressure from the protesters and the Western governments, primarily the US government, which generally sided with the opposition. But on February 18, 2014, the Maidan Self-Defense and the Right Sector attempted to storm the parliament, attacked the police units guarding it with “Molotov cocktails” and stones, and burned the Party of Regions headquarters and killed one of its employees during a Euromaidan opposition rally. The special police units and “titushki” dispersed and beaten both the violent attackers and peaceful protesters, killing

several of them, while a certain number of the protesters started to use live ammunition and kill and wound Berkut policemen and Interior Troops servicemen. The opposition-led protesters also seized regional administrations, police, and security services headquarters in Western Ukraine and some other regions, primarily in the Center. In contrast, the opposition protests in Eastern and Southern Ukraine, especially in Crimea and Donbas, during the Euromaidan were limited, and they were often confronted there by the pro-government “titushki.”

The Yanukovych government authorized use of force to seize the Maidan and its headquarters in the Trade Union building as a part of the “Boomerang” and “Khvyliia” plans. But after these attempts to seize the Maidan and the Maidan Self-Defense and Right Sector headquarters at the occupied Trade Union building in Kyiv City were stopped by use of live ammunition from elements of the Maidan opposition, including the Right Sector, and by their burning down of this building, Yanukovych agreed to negotiations with opposition leaders on February 19, 2014. A truce deal was negotiated between Yanukovych and the opposition leaders. But the leader of the Right Sector stated shortly after the midnight on February 20 that his organization did not accept this truce, and he threatened to use force.¹⁰

A comprehensive analysis of publicly available evidence suggests that the government of Viktor Yanukovych was overthrown as a result of mass killings of the police and protesters and that elements of the “Euromaidan” opposition, including the far right, were involved in this violence in order to gain power after mostly peaceful mass protests failed to achieve such an outcome. Such evidence includes publicly available but unreported, suppressed, or misrepresented videos and photos of suspected shooters, live statements by the Maidan announcers, radio intercepts of the actual “shooters,” and snipers and commanders from the special Alfa unit of the Security Service of Ukraine (SBU), ballistic trajectories, eyewitness

reports by both Maidan protesters and government special units commanders, public statements by the government officials, similar ammunition and weapons used against the police and the protesters, and similar types of wounds among both protesters and the police.¹¹

For example, different sources contain evidence of shooters or spotters in at least 12 buildings occupied by the Euromaidan opposition or located within the general territory held by them during the massacre on February 20. This includes the Hotel Ukraina, Zhovtnevyi Palace, Kinopalats, Bank “Arkada,” other buildings on both sides of Instytutska Street, and several buildings on the Maidan (Independence Square) itself, such as the Music Conservatory, the Trade Union headquarters, and the Main Post Office. The evidence also indicates that in addition to more than 60 Euromaidan protesters, 17 members of special police units were killed and 196 wounded from the Maidan-controlled buildings by similar types of ammunition and weapons on February 18-20, 2014.¹²

If Yanukovych went along with his plans to use force, including live ammunition and military units to suppress the “Euromaidan,” this would likely resulted in a large numbers of casualties among the protesters, a full-fledged uprising in opposition stronghold in Western Ukraine, and probably a civil war. But in order to preserve his power after the “sniper’s massacre” severely undermined his legitimacy among many of his Party of Regions deputies, police, security and military forces, government officials, and the population even in his party strongholds in Eastern and Southern Ukraine, he agreed to a compromise deal negotiated with the opposition with participation of foreign ministers of France, Germany and Poland and a Russian government representative on February 21, 2014. However, Yanukovych fled from Kyiv City and then from Ukraine after elements of the Euromaidan opposition reneged on the compromise agreement and threatened resumption of violence.

The violent overthrow of the relatively pro-Russian government, specifically by means of mass killings of the police and protesters, was a tipping point in the conflict between the West and Russia over Ukraine, because Western governments backed this regime change, while the Russian government opposed it. Putin used this development to radically change its policy, and he started backing separatists in Crimea and secession of this region with help of direct military intervention, and then Russia annexed Crimea in a violation of international law.

The mass killing of the protesters and the police that resulted in the overthrow of the Yanukovych government was a critical juncture that gave a start to a large-scale violent conflict, which took a form of a pro-Russian separatist rebellion in Donbas in Eastern Ukraine. In addition to peaceful rallies against the Euromaidan-led government, which included several members of far right Svoboda, unarmed and armed separatists seized regional administration, security service, and police headquarters, primarily, in the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions. The analysis of live broadcasts, videos, and media reports shows that the separatist leaders, commanders and members of their armed units, were mostly residents of Donbas, and to a lesser extent other regions of Ukraine, including Crimea. They included ethnic Russian nationalists, anti-Maidan activists, a part of local Communist Party and Party of Regions activists, and former members of Berkut and SBU.

But a significant number of volunteers and mercenaries came to Donbas from Russia. They included Russian nationalists, including radical nationalists, some neo-Nazis, Russian Cossacks, Chechens, Ingushes, and Ossetians. For example, one such armed group led by Igor Strelkov seized control over towns of Sloviansk and Kramatorsk in the Donetsk Region.

The analysis shows that much of the evidence that the separatist conflict in Donbas resulted from a direct Russian military intervention was misrepresented or even fabricated. This

concerns Ukrainian and Western governments' claims that Russian military and intelligence units or "green men" were leading the separatist fight in Donbas since it started in spring 2014. For example, Strelkov and other Russian members of his armed group in Sloviansk and Kramatorsks were identified by the Ukrainian and US governments as a Russian military intelligence (GRU) unit. However, the publicly available evidence indicates that Strelkov was a retired officer of the Federal Security Service (FSB), while a "bearded man" from the Strelkov group had been falsely identified as a commander of a Chechen GRU battalion solely on the basis of superficial similarity of their facial features.

The Russian government initially denied its direct military intervention in Crimea in March 2014, in spite of evidence that Russian military units without insignia ("green men") were operating along with separatist self-defense units, which included many Berkut members, in Crimea beyond the Russian naval base in Sevastopol and that they were seizing Ukrainian military units and government headquarters there. Evidence indicates that in contrast with direct military intervention in Crimea, Russia initially supported separatists in Donbas by allowing volunteers and weapons to cross the border from Russia, and in providing weapons, recruitment, training, and safe haven to separatists. Russia also threatened to use a military force in Ukraine, and it deployed large numbers of military personnel near the border with the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions and other regions of Ukraine the first time in spring and then again in summer of 2014.

Various sources indicate that in spite of continuing denial by the Russian government, a direct Russian military intervention in Donbas began in the end of August 2014. It took form of incursions by several battalion-size units in support of a counterattack by separatist forces. Such sources include videos of a Russian military convoy, videos of captured Russian soldiers and

equipment, first-hand reports by Western media and eyewitnesses, and released satellite images of Russian military vehicles on the Ukrainian side of the border.¹³

The indirect evidence of actual Russian military intervention includes a relatively rapid change in the military situation in Donbas. Until the end of August, separatists were under attacks of the Ukrainian forces, and they, with some exceptions, were retreating since the beginning of July from Sloviansk, Kramatorsk, and other areas of the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions to much more densely populated parts of Donbas, in particular, cities of Donetsk and Luhansk. The Ukrainian forces included not only regular army units but also special police battalions and the National Guard. Several of these battalions, such as Azov, Aidar, and Dnipro, were formed with significant involvement of the Right Sector, including the neo-Nazi Social-National Assembly. The National Guard was established on the basis of Interior Troops units and the Maidan Self-Defense.

However, in the end of August following a direct Russian military incursion in Donbas Ukrainian forces and special police battalions suffered a defeat. A large number of their members were encircled, killed, wounded, or captured, primarily near the town of Illovaisk, and they had to retreat from parts of the previously-held territories. A rapid reversal by President Poroshenko from his reliance on military force to defeat separatists and his refusal to negotiate with them to a cease fire agreement signed by his representative with DNR and LNR leaders Minsk on September 5, 2014. In addition, rapid changes in the top leadership of DNR and LNR in the mid-August preceded the Russian military intervention in Donbas. This includes replacements of Alexander Borodai, prime minister of DNR and Strelkov, the defense minister of DNR, with local separatist leaders and the return of these two Russian DNR leaders to Russia.

There were relatively small numbers of volunteers or mercenaries from other countries, such as Serbia, Poland, Spain, and the US, in the separatist units. Comparable numbers of volunteers and mercenaries who were citizens of foreign countries, such as Belarus, Canada, France, Italy, Russia, and the US served in special police battalions. They mainly joined the Azov battalion, de facto led by the neo-Nazi Social National Assembly. In addition to large numbers of Maidan Self-Defense in the National Guard units and special police battalions, more than 1,000 Right Sector members served in Donbas in such National Guard and special police units and the Volunteer Corp organized by this far right organization.

The violent conflict in Donbas can be defined as a civil war with a direct and indirect military involvement of a foreign state. In addition to the relatively late and limited Russian military intervention and the domination of people from Donbas, and, to a lesser extent, other regions of Eastern and Southern Ukraine, including Crimea among the separatist leaders and members of their armed formations, the composition and the number of casualties fit the widely used civil war definitions in political science and conflict studies.

The battle-related casualties of the war in Donbas far exceeded a 1,000 killed mark often used to distinguish civil wars from lower intensity violent conflicts. As of October 5, 2014, the casualties reached estimated 5,000 people killed, including some 2,500 civilians, close to 1,500 Ukrainian regular forces and special battalion members, about 1,000 members of separatist armed formations, and roughly 100 Russian regular military members. These estimates are based on official casualty reports, which are updated and adjusted for significant undercounting of killed separatists and missing in action members of the Ukrainian forces and civilian residents. The estimates of separatist and Russian military casualties are less certain, since they are projected on the basis of media reports about specific casualties and Ukrainian forces casualties.

The civilian casualties include 298 passengers and crewmembers of a Malaysian Airlines plane, which was shot down in the Donetsk Region, most likely by separatists.

The United Nations reported its “very conservative” estimate of at least 3,627 killed (including the plane casualties) and 8,446 wounded in eastern Ukraine as of September 30, 2014 out of 5.1 million people living in conflict-affected areas. In addition, there were 379,059 internally displaced people and 426,995 who fled to neighboring countries, primarily Russia, as of October 3, 2014. Emergency health care and forensic services of Donetsk and Luhansk Regions reported 2,232 people, including 35 children, killed and 5,103 people, including 87 children, wounded as of September, 30. They were primarily civilian residents of these regions, but a smaller proportion was armed separatists.¹⁴ The analysis of various sources of evidence, specifically concerning several disputed attacks, indicates that the absolute majority of civilian casualties resulted from shelling by the Ukrainian forces of cities, towns, and villages used by armed separatists as their bases. They included both collateral casualties from shelling and shooting at armed separatists by the Ukrainian forces and indiscriminate or deliberate bombardments and shootings of civilian areas and civilians.

This study estimates combined Ukrainian forces losses in Donbas close to 1,500 people killed. Petro Poroshenko stated on October 3, 2014 that 967 members of Ukrainian regular military, police, the National Guard, border guards, security services, and special police battalions members were killed there.¹⁵ But this number significantly undercounts the casualties since it does not include those who were killed but classified as missing in actions (MIA). More than 400 bodies were still unidentified. They were likely to be mostly Ukrainian forces missing in action, since there were 504 such people reported by name in addition to 806 POWs as of September 22, 2014.¹⁶

A national survey conducted for the author by the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology (KIIS) in April/May 2014 provides representative data concerning support and determinants of support for separatism in Donbas, compared to other regions of Ukraine, with exception of Crimea, which was not included in the sample. This survey shows that the majority residents of Donbas in April/May 2014 backed different forms of separatism (54 percent overall or 61 percent excluding undecided). Such support for separatism in Donbas far exceeded separatist support in three Eastern regions neighboring Donbas (15 percent) and in the South (10 percent). (Table 1).

[Table 1 about here]

Separatism includes not only outright secessionism but also unilateral demands of greater autonomy or federalism. In Ukraine, many separatist leaders, including in Donbas, prior to the time of the 2014 KIIS survey called for federalism and regional autonomy in Ukraine, while the Ukrainian government rejected both secessionism and federalism and treated it as a crime. The Russian government also then pressed for a federalism and significant regional autonomy which would have given Donbas powers to block decisions of the central government, including on matters of foreign policy.

In the 2014 KIIS survey, 23 percent of the respondents in Donbas, favored autonomy as a part of federal Ukraine, compared to 8 percent supporting independence of their region and 23 percent favoring their region joining Russia. Conversely, preserving current status of their regions within a unitary Ukraine but with expanded powers had a minority support in Donbas, in contrast to all other regions. The 2014 KIIS survey results show that views expressed by the Russian government and the media concerning widespread popular support for separatism in all

Eastern and Southern Ukraine, referred by President Putin and pro-Russian separatists as Novorossia, were unfounded.

Ethnic Russian constitute close to half of the population in the Donetsk and Luhansk Region. Donbas is a region with the biggest proportion of Russians in the population after Crimea. The 2014 KIIS Survey shows that ethnic Russians in Ukraine were split on the issue of separatism. Similar percentages of ethnic Russians, including people with mixed Russian and Ukrainian descent, supported preservation of the current unitary system (40 percent), mostly with expanded powers and different separatist options (44 percent), in particular, joining Russia (18 percent). (Table 2). In contrast, only 24 percent of Russian speakers, who include many ethnic Ukrainians, favored secession from Ukraine or regional autonomy in federal Ukraine. (See Table 3).

[Table 2 and 3 about here]

No major national political party in Ukraine openly supported the separatists in Donbas. The Ukrainian government not only prohibited separatist parties and organizations in Ukraine, but it initiated a prohibition of the Communist Party on separatism charges, and launched criminal cases against some leaders of the Party of Regions on similar charges of separatism. However, a significant proportion of local leaders and members of the Party of Regions and the Communist Party in Donbas backed separatists. The 2014 KIIS Survey shows that 20 percent of the intended voters for the Party of Regions and 15 percent for the Communist Party favored secession from Ukraine and joining another state, which means in almost all cases Russia, or secession from Ukraine and formation of independent state. Autonomy of their regions as a part of federal Ukraine was preferred by 18 percent of the Communist voters and 19 percent of the Party of Regions voters. But 22 percent of the respondents who did not intend to vote expressed

secessionist views, and 12 percent of them supported autonomy of their region as a part of a federal state in Ukraine. (See Table 4).

[Table 4 and 5 about here]

Multiple regression analysis of the 2014 KIIS Survey data shows that, when other factors are held constant, residents of Donbas expressed far greater support for separatism compared to other regions. Pro-separatist views were also stronger in other neighboring Eastern regions (Dnipropetrovsk, Kharkiv, and Zaporizhzhia Regions). Ethnic Russians, other ethnic minorities, Communist Party voters, younger people, adherents of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church (Moscow Patriarchate), and men expressed higher support for separatism. All these determinants of separatism were statistically significant. (Table 5).

In contrast, other historical regional variables, political parties, religious confessions, the Russian language, the education level, and settlement size did not have positive and statistically significant effects on support of separatism. Age and a voting preference for Solidarity, a party of Petro Poroshenko, who was elected as president of Ukraine in May 2014, had a negative effect on pro-separatist attitudes. (See Table 5). The attitudes towards separatism are measured on a scale from 1 to 3, with 1 meaning support for preservation of the respondents' region in unitary Ukraine with current or expanded powers of regions, 2 defining support for federal Ukraine with significant regional autonomy, and 3 expressing support for secession of their region from Ukraine and joining another state or becoming independent.

The Separatist Conflict in Donbas in a Comparative Perspective

The separatist conflict in the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions is most similar to violent conflicts and secessions in other post-Soviet states, such as Transdniestria in Moldova, Abkhazia

and South Ossetia in Georgia, Nagorno-Karabakh in Azerbaijan, and Chechnya in Russia. In all these cases, separatist movements emerged in regions populated mostly or to a large extent by an ethnic minority. The governments of these countries refused to offer or preserve autonomy of these regions, and relied on military or police forces and paramilitary units to suppress separatism. But such attempts by central government to defeat or suppress separatisms failed, with a partial exception of Chechnya after the second Chechen war. As result of violent conflicts, these regions became de facto independent. But their independence was not recognized by other countries, with some exceptions, such as recognition of Chechnya by the Taliban government in Afghanistan and recognition of South Ossetia and Abkhazia by Russia and several other countries.

The DNR and the LNR also became de facto independent, but they are unlikely to be recognized by the Western states and the absolute majority of other countries, with possible exception of Russia. The DNR and LNR, similarly to the Transdniestrian Republic, Abkhazia, and South Ossetia, expressed desire that their self-proclaimed states join Russia. However, the cases of these regions of Moldova and Georgia suggest that Russia would be unlikely to incorporate the separatist entities in Donbas, as it did in the case of Crimea.

Similarly to Donbas, separatist conflicts in Moldova and Georgia were not started by the Soviet or Russian governments, but these governments provided economic and political support and indirect military support, for instance in the form of peace-keeping forces that helped the separatist entities to maintain their status quo in face of more powerful military forces of Moldovan and Georgian governments. Like in the case of Donbas, Russia resorted to direct military support of separatists in Crimea in 2014 and in Abkhazia and South Ossetia during the

2008 war with Georgia. Similarly, Armenia offered its direct military support to Armenian separatists in Nagorno Karabakh and it occupied several neighboring Azeri districts.

Like in Donbas, separatist movement in Moldova, in particular, initially received much stronger support from hardline communist and nationalist opposition to Mikhail Gorbachev and to Boris Yeltsin. Russian volunteers and mercenaries participated on the side of separatists in the conflicts in Transdniestria, for instance, Strelkov and Borodai, and in Abkhazia. The UNA-UNSO, a Ukrainian radical nationalist organization, fought on the side of separatists in Transdniestria and in Chechnya. Many Arab volunteers fought against the Russian forces during the second war in Chechnya, while Chechen volunteers, such as Shamil Basaev, were on the same side with Russian volunteers and mercenaries during the war in Abkhazia. North Ossetian volunteers participated in the war in South Ossetia, and Armenian volunteers in the war in Nagorno Karabakh. Like in the case of Donbas, some foreigners occupied top positions in the separatist governments or their armed formations. This concerns for example, Nagorno Karabakh, South Ossetia, and Transdniestria.

A comparative analysis shows that a separatist conflict in Donbas is comparable to many civil wars and other intrastate conflicts, which included direct or indirect foreign countries involvement. Such cases include armed conflicts in the following countries: Moldova, Georgia, Tajikistan, Spain, Sri Lanka, Bosnia, Libya, Syria, Nicaragua, Angola, Mozambique, China, Lebanon, and the US. A possibility of a large-scale Russian military intervention in Donbas and, to a lesser extent, other regions in the East and the South, and a war between Ukraine and Russia remains. If such a war would happen, this conflict would be in addition to the civil war in Donbas. For example, US-led military interventions followed civil wars in Afghanistan, Libya, and Syria or preceded civil wars, like in the case of Iraq.

Like in the case of the conflict in Donbas, there were misrepresentations of other high-profile conflicts by the governments and the media in both Russia and Western countries. As noted, this includes the initial Russian denial of its military intervention in Crimea. Other such cases include misrepresentations by the US government and the media of presence of weapons of mass destruction and links to al Qaeda in Iraq during the 2003 US-led war, and their overestimation of the strength of moderate and democratic elements in the opposition forces and underestimation of fundamentalist Islamist rebel organizations in the Syrian civil war. the 2008 Russian-Georgian war was misrepresented in the US and to a large extent Canadian media by ignoring that it started as a result of the Georgian government attack of South Ossetia, and Russian peacekeeping forces in this the de-facto independent separatist region. Similarly, the US media often ignored that the second war in Chechnya started with attack of Dagestan by the Chechen Islamist militia.

There are also similarities of the conflict in Donbas and violent separatist conflicts in Krajina in Croatia, Republika Srpska in Bosnia, Kosovo in Serbia, and in Albanian-populated region of Macedonia. But the conflict in Donbas is unlikely to be resolved similarly to a Croatian military defeat of Serbian separatists in Krajina, or Bosnian peaceful compromise resulting in a confederation-type political system under international administration, a Kosovo-style unilateral but independence recognized by many countries, or a Macedonia-style peaceful deal offering the Albania minority significant rights at the national level. Similarly, Quebec or Scotland type referendums to determine the independence of the regions are also unlikely. Unless radical changes in leaderships of these countries, the Ukrainian government, the US and other Western countries, or Russia would not accept all such solutions of the Donbas conflict. For example, the

US and EU governments opposed the Kozak plan, which was advanced by Russia and which would have transformed Moldova into a de-facto confederation.

In contrast to Bosnia and Kosovo, no direct Western or NATO military intervention in the Donbas conflict is realistic, because it would bring a possibility of a war with nuclear-armed Russia. The Western governments are likely to continue relying on political and economic sanctions against Russia and separatists in Donbas. But political science studies and experience of many previous cases of such Western sanctions, for example, against Russia after its annexation of Crimea, or against Cuba, Iraq, Iran, and the Soviet Union during the Afghan war, suggest that they are unlikely to achieve their goal of stopping Russian support to separatists in Donbas. The West would mostly continue offering political backing and economic aid to the pro-Western Ukrainian government, primarily in forms of bilateral loans or loans from international organizations, such as the International Monetary Fund and the EU.

Membership or prospects of membership in the EU or NATO for Croatia, Cyprus, Bosnia, Macedonia, Kosovo, and Serbia had affected or had potential to affect resolution of separatist conflicts in these countries. But they could not resolve them permanently and completely. The cases of other post-Soviet states with separatist conflicts, such as Moldova and Georgia, indicate that the Western governments are unlikely to accept Ukraine into the European Union or NATO in a foreseeable future. Russia's support for separatists in Donbas helps inter alia to prevent a possibility of such a membership.

Conclusion

This study indicates that the conflict in Donbas is unlikely to be resolved in the near future. This war can either turn into a frozen conflict, similar to Transdniestria, Abkhazia, South

Ossetia, and Nagorno Karabakh, or the violence can escalate again. The civil war in Donbas with help of indirect and direct Russian military support led to de facto independence of the DNR and the LNR, which attained control the most populated areas of the Donetsk and Luhansk Regions. Combined with separation and annexation of Crimean autonomy and Sevastopol city with help of Russian military intervention, the existence of the separatist entities in Donbas signifies a de facto break up of Ukraine.

The analysis shows that all major actors, specifically the “Euromaidan” opposition, including its far right wing, separatists, the Yanukovych and the post-Yanukovych governments, and the Russian and Western governments contributed in different ways to the violent separatist conflict in Donbas and de-facto break-up of Ukraine. But their actions did not have equal impact. This study suggests that it would be practically impossible to resolve the conflict in Donbas completely and permanently and to unite Ukraine again.

Table 1. Support for separatism in different regions of Ukraine, the 2014 KIIS Survey, percent

	Donbas	Other East	South *	Center	Buko vyna	Galicia	Transca rpathia	Volhy nia
Secession from Ukraine and joining another state	23	3	2	1	0	0	0	0
Secession from Ukraine and formation of independent state	8	2	1	0	0	0	0	0
Autonomy as a part of federal Ukraine	23	10	7	2	0	0	0	0
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with expanded powers	26	55	59	54	69	68	84	59
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with current powers	9	18	23	31	13	22	11	40
Don't know/Not sure	11	12	8	12	18	10	5	1
Total, %	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100
N	311	377	214	704	39	224	55	94

Note: * Crimea is not included

Table 2. Support for separatism by major ethnic groups in Ukraine, the 2014 KIIS Survey,
percent

	Ukrainians	Russians	Both Russian & Ukrainian	Other
Secession from Ukraine and joining another state	2	16	25	14
Secession from Ukraine and formation of independent state	1	6	9	3
Autonomy as a part of federal Ukraine	5	20	18	14
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with expanded powers	57	35	23	29
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with current powers	25	8	9	23
Don't know/Not sure	10	16	18	17
Total, %	100	100	100	100
N	1693	229	57	35

Note: Crimea is not included

Table 3. Support for separatism by major languages in Ukraine, the 2014 KIIS Survey, percent

	Ukrainian	Russian	Mixture of Russian & Ukrainian
Secession from Ukraine and joining another state	1	9	3
Secession from Ukraine and formation of independent state	1	3	2
Autonomy as a part of federal Ukraine	1	12	5
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with expanded powers	61	45	57
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with current powers	28	18	24
Don't know/Not sure	8	13	10
Total, %	100	100	100
N	802	934	284

Note: Crimea is not included

Table 4. Support for separatism by major political parties in Ukraine, the 2014 KIIS Survey, percent

	Fatherland	Svoboda	Communist Party	Party of Regions	Solidarity	UDAR	Our Ukraine	Other Party	Against All	Won't vote	Don't Know/ Not Sure
Secession from Ukraine and joining another state	1	2	14	14	0	0	0	0	5	17	3
Secession from Ukraine and formation of independent state	0	2	1	6	0	0	7	0	5	5	1
Autonomy as a part of federal Ukraine	2	1	18	19	1	1	5	4	13	12	7
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with expanded powers	56	57	40	45	67	70	54	68	46	27	52
Preserving current status within unitary Ukraine with current powers	30	30	14	8	25	22	34	22	20	22	23
Don't know/ Not sure	11	8	13	9	6	7	0	5	11	18	14
Total, %	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100	100
N	202	77	95	116	362	191	19	72	199	222	465

Note: * Crimea is not included

Table 5. Determinants of support for separatism in Ukraine, 2014 KIIS survey, OLS regression

	Unstandardized Regression coefficient (B)	Standardized Regression coefficient (Beta)
Volhynia	-.052	-.020
Transcarpathia	-.035	-.010
Bukovyna	-.025	-.006
Center	.035	.029
Donbas	.711***	.452
Other East	.120*	.082
South****	.071	.039
Ethnic Russian	.331***	.199
Other ethnic minority	.234**	.052
Russian-speaker	-.037	-.032
Male	.064**	.057
Age	-.003***	-.079
Education	-.009	-.030
Settlement type	.009	.039
Fatherland	-.060	-.032
Svoboda	-.033	-.011
Communist Party	.159**	.059
Party of Regions	.091	.038
Solidarity	-.129***	-.088
Our Ukraine	-.180	-.033
Other Parties	-.138*	-.046
Against All	-.030	-.016
Orthodox (Moscow Patriarchate)	.114**	.078
Orthodox Autocephalous	-.015	-.003
Orthodox (Kyiv Patriarchate)	.016	.013
Greek Catholic	.034	.015
Other Religions	-.113	-.026
No religious confession	.055	.043
Constant	1.141***	
Adjusted R Square	.373	
N	1801	

*** Statistically significant at the .001 level, ** statistically significant at the .01 level, * statistically significant at the .05 level. **** does not include Crimea.

Notes

¹ See, for example, Dominique Arel, "The Orange Revolution's hidden face: Ukraine and the denial of its regional problem," *Revue Detudes Comparatives Est-Ouest* 37 (2006): 11-48; Lowell Barrington and Regina Faranda, "Reexamining Region, Ethnicity, and Language in Ukraine," *Post-Soviet Affairs* 25 (2009): 232-256; Lowell Barrington and Erick Herron, "One Ukraine or Many?: Regionalism in Ukraine and its political consequences," *Nationalities Papers* 32 (2004): 53-86; Sarah Birch, *Elections and Democratization in Ukraine* (New York: St. Martin Press, 2000); Sarah Birch, "Interpreting the Regional Effect in Ukrainian Politics," *Europe-Asia Studies* 52 (2000): 1017-1042; Ralph S. Clem and Peter R. Craumer, "Orange, Blue and White, and Blonde: The Electoral Geography of Ukraine's 2006 and 2007 Rada Elections," *Eurasian Geography and Economics* 49 (2008): 127-151; Ralph S. Clem and Peter R. Craumer, "Shades of Orange: The Electoral Geography of Ukraine's 2004 Presidential Elections," *Eurasian Geography and Economics* 46 (2005): 364-385; Timothy J. Colton, "An Aligning Election and the Ukrainian Political Community," *East European Politics and Societies*, 25 (2011): 4-27; Vicki Hesli, William Reisinger, and Arthur Miller, "Political Party Development in Divided Societies: The Case of Ukraine," *Electoral Studies* 17 (1998): 235-256; Ivan Katchanovski, *Cleft Countries: Regional Political Divisions and Cultures in Post-Soviet Ukraine and Moldova* (Stuttgart: Ibidem-Verlag, 2006); Ivan Katchanovski, "Regional Political Divisions in Ukraine in 1991-2006," *Nationalities Papers* 34 (2006): 507-532; Ivan Katchanovski, "Regional Political Cleavages, Electoral Behavior, and Historical Legacies in Ukraine," in Bredies, Umland, and Yakushik, eds., *Aspects of the Orange Revolution III*, 55-77 (2007); Ivan Katchanovski, "East or West? Regional Political Divisions in Ukraine since the "Orange Revolution" and the "Euromaidan,"" paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the American Political Science

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² Katchanovski, "Cleft Countries."

³ Timothy J. Colton, "Thinking the Unthinkable: Is the Breakup of the Ukrainian State a Real Threat?" Paper presented at the Sixth Annual Danyliw Research Seminar, University of Ottawa, (October 2010); Keith A. Darden, "Conditional Property and Regional Political Cultures: Challenges for U.S. Foreign Policy in the Post-Soviet Space," in Timothy Colton, Timothy Frye, and Robert Legvold, eds., *The Policy World Meets Academia: Designing U.S. Policy toward Russia* (Cambridge: American Academy of Arts & Sciences, 2010), 70-78; Katchanovski, *Cleft Countries*.

⁴ Katchanovski, "Cleft Countries."

⁵ Gwendolyn Sasse, *The Crimea Question: Identity, Transition, and Conflict* (Cambridge: Harvard Ukrainian Research Institute, 2007); Taras Kuzio, *Ukraine - Crimea - Russia: Triangle of Conflict* (Stuttgart: Ibidem-Verlag, 2007).

⁶ See Katchanovski, "Cleft Countries," 99-100; Katchanovski, "East or West?," Serhiy Kudelia, "Domestic Sources of the Donbas Insurgency," *PONARS Eurasia Policy Memo*, No. 351 (2014), <http://www.ponarseurasia.org/memo/domestic-sources-donbas-insurgency>.

⁷ Keith Darden, "How to Save Ukraine." *Foreign Affairs* (October 6, 2014), <http://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/141182/keith-darden/how-to-save-ukraine>; Ivan Katchanovski, "Sizing up Ukraine's Euromaidan," *OpenDemocracy*, (December 3, 2013), <https://www.opendemocracy.net/od-russia/ivan-katchanovski/sizing-up-ukraines-euromaidan>.

⁸ See, for instance, US Department of State, Office of the Spokesperson, “Russian Fiction the Sequel: 10 More False Claims about Ukraine” (April 13, 2014),

<http://www.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/04/224759.htm>.

⁹ “Sledstvennyi komitet vzbudil ugovnoe delo o genotside russkoyazychnogo naseleniya na yugo-vostoke Ukrainy,” (September 29, 2014), <http://www.sledcom.ru/actual/417477>.

¹⁰ See Ivan Katchanovski, “The “Snipers’ Massacre” on the Maidan in Ukraine,”

https://www.academia.edu/8776021/The_Snipers_Massacre_on_the_Maidan_in_Ukraine.

¹¹ See Katchanovski, “The “Snipers’ Massacre” and, for instance, an unreported intercept of radio communications of the Security Service of Ukraine Alfa commanders during the massacre in the morning of February 20, 2014, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ziTW0PG7SBM>.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ See, for example, “Sky Films Troops 'In Russian Gear' In Ukraine,” *Sky News*, (September 3, 2014), <http://news.sky.com/story/1329691/sky-films-troops-in-russian-gear-in-ukraine>.

¹⁴ UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, “Ukraine. Situation report No.14 as of 3 October 2014” (October 3, 2014), <http://reliefweb.int/report/ukraine/ukraine-situation-report-no-14-3-october-2014>.

¹⁵ “Poroshenko: Ne rasproniaite lozh FSB o tysiache pogibshikh pod Ilovaiskom,” (October 3, 2014), http://zik.ua/ru/news/2014/10/03/poroshenko_ne_rasprostranyayte_lozh_fsb_o_tisyache_pogybshyh_pod_ylovayskom_528988.

¹⁶ “Opublikovano spysky znyklykh i polonenykh – povnyi perelik,” (September 23, 2014), <http://www.pravda.com.ua/news/2014/09/23/7038625>.

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